

Return to the sea

Around January to February, the young penguin is ready to go to the sea for the first time. When it is about three years old, it will be ready to mate, and the life cycle can begin again.

See also

To find out more about life in extreme environments, see polar bears (124–125).

Molting

By December, the chick starts to molt—it sheds its down and starts to grow smooth waterproof feathers. This means the young penguin will soon be ready to swim.

The parents take turns going to the sea to hunt, returning to feed their chick.

By September, the chick can stand on the ice unsupported.

Feeding

The mother feeds her chick by bringing up food stored in her stomach. The food is like a paste or oil by this stage.

Hatching

The mother returns from the sea around August. Sometimes the egg has already hatched, but if not, she takes the egg back from the father. Once the egg hatches, she keeps the chick warm in her brood pouch.

The penguin chick has a thin layer of feathery down when it hatches.

Huddle From October to November, while the parents are hunting for food, the penguin chicks huddle together in groups to keep warm.



Diving Emperor penguins are great swimmers and divers. They can stay underwater for up to 20 minutes while hunting for food.



Enemies Emperor penguins have few predators, but they have to watch out for leopard seals who might pounce and attack them.

